

SAR-to-Optical image Translation

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Abstract

Cloud cover remains a persistent challenge in optical remote sensing, limiting the usability of optical satellite imagery for continuous Earth observation. Synthetic Aperture Radar (SAR) data, in contrast, provides cloud-penetrating, all-weather imaging but lacks the spectral and visual richness of optical observations. Bridging these complementary modalities, this study investigates SAR-to-optical image translation using the Pix2Pix conditional generative adversarial network (cGAN). While existing research predominantly focuses on reconstructing only the visible (RGB) or near-infrared bands, this work employs the winter subset of the SEN12-MS dataset to address the full spectral range. The objectives are threefold: (i) to validate SAR-to-optical translation across all 13 Sentinel-2 spectral bands; (ii) to assess the reliability and reconstructability of each individual band; and (iii) to evaluate the performance of the translation model for cloud removal. Experimental results show that the model effectively learns the SAR-to-optical mapping and achieves high reconstruction quality across all spectral bands, though bandwise analysis reveals that reconstruction accuracy varies with spectral characteristics. When applied to the SEN12-MS-CR dataset, the model successfully generates cloud-free optical imagery that closely matches reference data, achieving performance competitive with state-of-the-art models such as DiffCR. Overall, the findings confirm the viability of SAR-to-optical translation for producing spectrally consistent, cloud-free optical imagery, thus enhancing the temporal continuity of Earth observation data. Two ablation studies further analyze the impact of different loss functions and the exclusion of 60 m bands. Additionally, based on data analysis, a new per-band clipping strategy for optical data is proposed.

Keywords: keyword 1; keyword 2; keyword 3 (List three to ten pertinent keywords specific to the article; yet reasonably common within the subject discipline.)

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1. Introduction

Earth observation has become an indispensable tool for understanding and monitoring the planet's dynamic processes. Optical and radar remote sensing represent two complementary modalities at the core of modern monitoring systems. Optical sensors, such as the Multi-Spectral Instrument (MSI) onboard Sentinel-2, provide rich spectral and visual information essential for applications ranging from agricultural monitoring and land-cover classification to disaster response and forest monitoring [1]. However, these sensors are inherently constrained by atmospheric conditions, particularly cloud cover. Global estimates suggest that average cloud cover exceeds 66% [4–6], with about 55% over land surfaces [6], causing considerable data gaps in both spatial and temporal domains. For applications requiring consistent time series, e.g., agricultural monitoring, or where a specific scene must be observed at a given time, e.g., disaster monitoring, cloud cover represents a serious limitation [6]. The diversity of clouds—including thin and thick clouds as well as haze—together with the wide range of occlusion scenarios and their uneven distribution, poses an additional challenge for image reconstruction and the generalizability of cloud removal techniques [7]. In contrast, Synthetic Aperture Radar (SAR) sensors, operating in the microwave domain, such as the C-band instrument on Sentinel-1 mission offer all-weather, day-and-night imaging capabilities independent of solar illumination or cloud interference. However, the backscatter-based nature of SAR imagery introduces challenges related to speckle noise, geometric distortions, and a lack of intuitive spectral color information [2,3], necessitating advanced interpretation skills.

To bridge the gap between these two sensing modalities, SAR-to-optical image translation has emerged as a powerful generative approach. It aims to synthesize optical-like, cloud-free imagery from SAR data, combining the interpretability of optical observations with the reliability of radar acquisitions. The domain gap between SAR and optical imagery, however, poses significant challenges. For example, while two objects with identical structures may appear different in optical imagery due to their spectral responses, they can appear similar in SAR imagery, reflecting SAR's emphasis on structural rather than spectral properties [16]. Moreover, acquiring perfectly co-registered SAR–optical pairs is also non-trivial, as both spatial and temporal alignment must be ensured.

Recent advances in generative artificial intelligence (GenAI), particularly in conditional generative adversarial networks (cGANs) [8] and diffusion models [9], have made it possible to learn complex mappings between SAR and optical domains with visually plausible results [10]. These developments have opened new pathways for applications in land-cover classification, vegetation monitoring, disaster response, and particularly, cloud removal. Despite the rapid progress in this field, a significant gap remains in the literature. Most existing studies have focused primarily on reconstructing the visible RGB subset of optical imagery such as [2,10,11,13,23], with a few extending to the Near-Infrared (NIR) range such as [14,15]. Consequently, the full multispectral potential of missions such as Sentinel-2 remains largely underexplored in the context of generative reconstruction. Critical bands for vegetation analysis (Red-Edge) and soil moisture monitoring (SWIR) are rarely addressed.

Furthermore, while SAR-to-optical translation is often evaluated qualitatively, systematic assessments of its reliability across individual spectral bands remain scarce. Finally, although the approach shows promise for cloud removal, its effectiveness in this context has not yet been comprehensively validated across the full spectral range.

Accordingly, this study investigates the use of generative models for translating Sentinel-1 SAR imagery into the full multispectral stack of Sentinel-2 imagery. The objectives of this work are threefold:

1. To validate SAR-to-optical image translation across all 13 Sentinel-2 spectral bands, moving beyond standard RGB constraints. 74
2. To systematically assess the reliability and reconstructability of each individual spectral band. 75
3. To evaluate the performance of the translation model for the practical application of cloud removal. 76

By addressing these objectives, this work aims to provide a comprehensive and quantitative understanding of SAR-to-optical translation as a multimodal learning problem and to clarify its potential and limitations for enhancing the temporal continuity of Earth observation data. 77

2. Related Work

2.1. Cloud Removal Methods (Overview)

Cloud removal methods in optical remote sensing are commonly grouped into three categories: (i) single-image methods, (ii) multimodal-based methods, and (iii) multitemporal-based methods [7].

Single-image methods aim to reconstruct surface information using only the cloudy optical image and typically rely on statistical or physical priors (e.g., frequency filtering or atmospheric scattering models). Zhang et al. [33] proposed the Haze Optimized Transformation (HOT) for thin cloud and haze compensation, while He et al. [34] introduced the dark channel prior, later adapted for thin cloud removal in optical remote sensing. With deep learning, CNNs, U-Nets, and GAN-based architectures have also been applied in this setting; however, single-image methods remain fundamentally limited under dense cloud cover due to missing surface information [7].

Multimodal-based methods integrate auxiliary data from complementary sensors to improve restoration. In practice, the most significant progress has been achieved by fusing SAR and optical imagery, leveraging the cloud-penetrating capability of SAR. Meraner et al. [6] proposed DSen2-CR, combining Sentinel-1 and Sentinel-2 to enhance reconstruction under thick clouds and preserve spectral fidelity. Grohnfeldt et al. [5] demonstrated the effectiveness of conditional GANs for SAR–optical fusion, and Xu et al. [35] proposed GLF-CR using a global–local fusion strategy. This line of work motivates SAR-to-optical translation approaches, which either translate SAR features into optical-like imagery or fuse SAR with partially corrupted optical inputs, while still facing challenges related to data registration, modality differences, and SAR speckle.

Multitemporal-based methods exploit repeated observations to fill cloud-covered regions. Xu et al. [28] proposed multitemporal dictionary learning for reconstructing thin and thick cloud regions without explicit cloud masks. Ebel et al. [30] introduced UnCRtainTS, combining multispectral reconstruction with per-pixel uncertainty estimation. While highly effective under persistent cloud cover, multitemporal approaches can be sensitive to geometric misalignment and temporal land-cover changes [36], and they require consistent time series data; mono-temporal approaches avoid such requirements and reduce co-registration constraints [37]. Given the focus of this work on mono-temporal SAR–optical generation, the following subsections review SAR-to-optical translation methods and their use for cloud removal.

2.2. SAR-to-Optical Image Translation

SAR-to-optical translation is defined as an image-to-image (I2I) task that synthesizes optical-like imagery from SAR data, despite the domain gap between backscatter intensity and spectral reflectance as well as SAR-specific artifacts such as speckle and geometric distortions. Before the emergence of generative AI, SAR-to-optical translation relied on heuristic or classical methods. Early approaches used pseudo-colorization of SAR channels or polarization composites to enhance interpretability [17], though they failed to reproduce true optical characteristics. Multisensor fusion methods, such as combining SAR with prior cloud-free optical data via intensity–hue–saturation (IHS) or wavelet-based transforms [18], provided partial solutions but depended on handcrafted features and complex preprocessing, limiting scalability and accuracy.

Recent deep learning approaches—most notably generative adversarial networks (GANs) [19] and diffusion models [9]—have enabled end-to-end learning of mappings from SAR to optical observations by modeling cross-modal feature relationships and pixel-level distributions. Most existing studies focus on reconstructing the visible (RGB) subset of Sentinel-2 (or extend to near-infrared), whereas comparatively fewer works address

full multispectral reconstruction; correspondingly, the literature often distinguishes SAR-to-optical translation from SAR-to-multispectral (SAR-to-MS) translation. In this paper, the term “optical” denotes the full 13-band Sentinel-2 spectral range, and the proposed methodology extends SAR-to-optical translation to the complete multispectral domain.

The foundational GAN framework by Goodfellow et al. [19], later extended to Conditional GANs (cGANs) by Mirza and Osindero [8], enabled image-to-image translation tasks that made SAR-to-optical synthesis feasible. Fuentes Reyes et al. [20] optimized an unsupervised CycleGAN for SAR-to-optical translation, improving interpretability and reducing speckle through customized preprocessing and architectural refinements, although fine structural details remained difficult to preserve in urban scenes. Wang et al. [21] introduced a Supervised CycleGAN (S-CycleGAN) by incorporating a pixel-wise MSE loss, producing realistic optical images and showing strong potential for cloud removal. Gao et al. [10] extended this idea with a fusion-based GAN framework for high-resolution imagery. Instead of directly translating SAR to optical, they generated a simulated optical image from SAR data and fused it with both SAR and optical inputs to reconstruct more realistic results. An ablation study confirmed that this two-stage fusion strategy achieved superior performance among tested configurations.

Following the success of Vision Transformers (ViTs) [22], transformer-based architectures have also emerged. Zhao et al. [23] proposed the Hybrid Vision Transformer cGAN (HVT-cGAN), combining CNN and ViT branches to capture both local details and global semantics. A Convolutional Attention Fusion Module (CAFM) adaptively merged multiscale features, enhancing texture and color fidelity. Trained on the SEN1-2 dataset [24], HVT-cGAN achieved superior visual and quantitative results over previous GAN-based models. Park et al. [25] further improved this approach with a multiscale ViT-based cGAN architecture integrating perceptual loss and a two-phase transfer learning strategy to enhance realism and stability.

Diffusion models have recently entered this field. Bai et al. [11] introduced a conditional diffusion model for SAR-to-optical translation, which, despite limited experimentation due to computational constraints, demonstrated promising performance compared to GAN-based methods. Bai et al. [13] later extended the framework with color supervision to improve reconstruction fidelity. A more recent contribution, the Multi-Temporal Conditional GAN (MTcGAN) by Kwak and Park [26], was designed for early-stage crop monitoring and utilized SAR–optical pairs from reference and prediction dates to capture temporal dynamics, achieving superior spectral consistency compared to conventional methods.

These developments have motivated the use of SAR-to-optical synthesis as a data-driven strategy for cloud removal, discussed next.

2.3. SAR-to-Optical Image Translation for Cloud Removal

SAR-guided cloud removal exploits the cloud-penetrating capability of SAR to reconstruct missing optical observations in cloud-contaminated scenes. Early methods relied on traditional signal processing techniques: Huang et al. [27] introduced sparse representation-based cloud removal using SAR data, which Xu et al. [28] extended via multi-temporal dictionary learning. These approaches demonstrated the feasibility of SAR-assisted cloud reconstruction but struggled under heavy cloud cover or rapidly changing surface conditions.

With deep learning, multimodal fusion approaches became dominant. Enomoto et al. [14] applied a cGAN for cloud removal by fusing the RGB composite of a cloudy optical image with the cloud-free near-infrared (NIR) band to reconstruct a cloud-free RGB image. Although limited under dense cloud conditions, the approach was pivotal in demonstrating

the potential of multimodal data fusion for cloud removal and laid the groundwork for subsequent studies. Building on this concept, Grohnfeldt et al. [5] introduced SAR-Opt-cGAN, a model designed to fuse Sentinel-1 SAR and Sentinel-2 optical data—marking the first use of SAR data within a cGAN framework for cloud mitigation. Their adaptation of the Pix2Pix architecture [29] allowed flexible multi-channel inputs and was trained on a subset of the SEN1-2 dataset [24]. The results confirmed the advantage of incorporating SAR data, validating the effectiveness of the approach for mitigating cloud cover.

Beyond direct cGAN fusion, specialized pipelines were proposed. Darbaghshahi et al. [2] introduced a dual-GAN framework with Dilated Residual Inception Blocks (DRIBs), translating SAR to optical in the first stage and fusing with cloudy optical inputs in the second; it showed strong qualitative results but moderate quantitative accuracy. Ebel et al. [30] advanced this direction with UnCRtainTS, which reconstructs multispectral imagery while predicting per-pixel uncertainty, improving performance and providing reliability indicators.

Recently, diffusion models have become highly competitive. Zou et al. [31] proposed DiffCR, a fast conditional diffusion framework and reported state-of-the-art on SEN12-MS-CR [32]. DiffCR employs a decoupled conditional architecture and a Time and Condition Fusion Block (TCFBlock), and predicts cloud-free images directly, enabling high-quality results in as few as 1–5 denoising steps with substantially reduced computational cost. In parallel, Meraner et al. [6] proposed DSen2-CR, a deep residual SAR–optical fusion network with a Cloud-Adaptive Regularized Loss (CARL) to preserve uncorrupted content while focusing reconstruction on clouded regions; evaluated on SEN12-MS-CR, it showed strong global generalization and high reconstruction accuracy across all 13 bands, with best performance on surface-related bands and higher errors on atmospheric bands.

Overall, the literature demonstrates a progression from classical SAR-guided reconstruction to deep multimodal fusion, uncertainty-aware prediction, and diffusion-based models, establishing SAR-to-optical translation as a strong paradigm for cloud removal. This work builds on that foundation by evaluating SAR-to-optical translation for cloud removal across the full 13-band Sentinel-2 spectrum and analyzing model behavior through bandwise evaluation and ablation studies.

3. Materials and Methods

3.1. Problem Formulation

The task of SAR-to-optical translation is formulated as a supervised image-to-image translation problem. Let $\mathcal{X} \subset \mathbb{R}^{H \times W \times C_{in}}$ denote the domain of SAR inputs, where $C_{in} = 2$ corresponds to the dual-polarized Sentinel-1 channels (VV, VH) expressed in the decibel (dB) scale. Similarly, let $\mathcal{Y} \subset \mathbb{R}^{H \times W \times C_{out}}$ denote the domain of optical reference images, where $C_{out} = 13$ represents the full multispectral stack of Sentinel-2.

The objective is to learn a parametric mapping function $G_\theta : \mathcal{X} \rightarrow \mathcal{Y}$, parameterized by θ , such that for a given SAR input $x \in \mathcal{X}$, the generated optical image $\hat{y} = G_\theta(x)$ is indistinguishable from the ground truth optical image $y \in \mathcal{Y}$ in terms of spectral and spatial characteristics.

We assume access to a paired dataset $\mathcal{D} = \{(x_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^M$ consisting of spatially co-registered SAR and optical patches acquired over the same geographical regions. The training objective is to find the optimal generator parameters θ^* that minimize a composite loss function $\mathcal{L}$ over the data distribution:

$$\theta^* = \arg \min_{\theta} \mathbb{E}_{(x,y) \sim \mathcal{D}} [\mathcal{L}(G_\theta(x), y)] \quad (1)$$

where $\mathcal{L}$ is a weighted combination of reconstruction, adversarial, and perceptual terms designed to collectively encourage pixel-level accuracy, structural consistency, and spectral fidelity. Specific details on the loss components and optimization strategy are provided in Section 3.4.

3.2. Dataset

This study utilizes the *SEN12-MS* dataset [38], curated by Schmitt et al. *SEN12-MS* is a large-scale, globally distributed benchmark explicitly designed to advance research in multimodal Earth observation and deep learning. It comprises 180,662 georeferenced image triplets, each consisting of: (i) dual-polarized Sentinel-1 synthetic aperture radar (SAR) data in VV and VH polarization (σ^0 backscatter values in decibel scale); (ii) full Sentinel-2 multispectral imagery spanning all 13 bands; and (iii) MODIS land cover maps derived from the MCD12Q1 product and resampled to 10 m resolution. Each triplet is stored as a 256×256 pixel GeoTIFF at 10 m ground sampling distance, corresponding to a spatial coverage of approximately 2.56×2.56 km per patch. The dataset has a total size of 510 GB, reflecting its high complexity, diversity, and spatial resolution.

The Sentinel-1 component originates from ground-range-detected (GRD) products acquired in interferometric wide swath (IW) mode. The Sentinel-2 imagery was curated using a cloud-free mosaicking workflow on Google Earth Engine, ensuring that each region of interest (ROI) is represented by seasonally consistent, nearly cloud-free multispectral data. Importantly, all triplets underwent manual verification by remote sensing experts to ensure freedom from major artifacts, severe registration errors, or residual cloud contamination.

The ROIs were sampled globally across all inhabited continents and four meteorological seasons of 2017 to maximize spatial and temporal diversity. For the purpose of SAR-to-optical translation, only the Sentinel-1 and Sentinel-2 modalities are utilized; the MODIS component is excluded. Sample data are depicted in Figure 1.

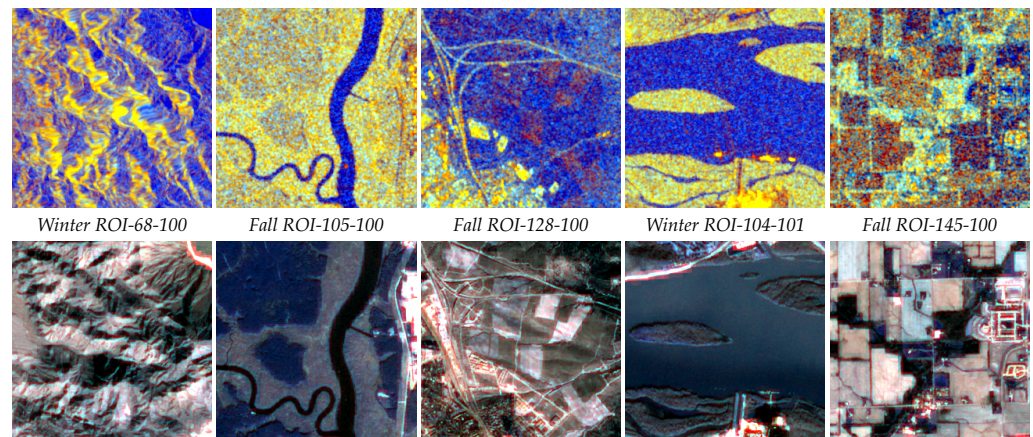


Figure 1. Sample pairs from the SEN12-MS dataset. Top row: Sentinel-1 SAR patches (R: VV, G: VH, B: VV/VH). Middle row: ROI IDs. Bottom row: corresponding Sentinel-2 multispectral patches (RGB visualization).

SEN12-MS is part of a broader family of datasets developed to foster multimodal remote sensing research. Its predecessor, SEN1-2 [24], provided SAR–optical pairs but lacked georeferencing, full spectral coverage, and dual-polarization SAR. SEN12-MS addressed these limitations, establishing a comprehensive multimodal benchmark. The family has since been extended by SEN12-MS-CR [32] (adding cloudy/cloud-free pairs) and SEN12-MS-CR-TS [39] (multimodal time series). This study focuses on SEN12-MS to leverage its global diversity for learning the core SAR-to-optical translation mapping.

3.2.1. Subset Selection and Preprocessing

The SEN12-MS dataset is divided into four seasonal subsets. Due to the computational demands of extensive experimentation and ablation studies, the *Winter* subset (containing 31,825 paired images) was selected for training and evaluation.

A custom preprocessing pipeline was implemented to standardize the input domains. Following established best practices in the literature [6,40–43], Sentinel-1 backscatter values were clipped to fixed physical ranges of $[-25, 0]$ dB for VV polarization and $[-32.5, 0]$ dB for VH polarization to suppress radiometric outliers. Similarly, Sentinel-2 top-of-atmosphere (TOA) reflectance values were clipped to the range $[0, 10,000]$. After clipping, all values were linearly normalized to the interval $[-1, 1]$ to align with the Tanh activation function of the generator’s output layer. The original spatial resolution of 256×256 pixels was preserved, and no data augmentation was applied given the inherent global diversity of the dataset.

3.3. Network Architecture

To address the SAR-to-optical translation task, we employ the Pix2Pix model, a cGAN originally introduced by Isola et al. [29]. The Pix2Pix framework has gained substantial recognition not only in general image-to-image translation [1], but also within the domain of SAR-to-optical translation. It is frequently employed as a baseline model as in [6,10,23,26,41,44], or further adapted and extended in various studies [5,44]. Owing to its demonstrated effectiveness and widespread adoption in related research, Pix2Pix was selected as the primary model for the experiments conducted in this work.

The framework consists of a generator G and a discriminator D trained in a minimax game, where G learns to map a dual-polarized SAR input x to a multispectral optical output y , while D attempts to distinguish between real pairs $\{x, y\}$ and synthesized pairs $\{x, G(x)\}$.

The generator is implemented as a U-Net encoder–decoder [45]. Unlike standard autoencoders, U-Net employs skip connections between mirror layers in the encoder and decoder stacks. These connections concatenate low-level feature maps from the down-sampling path directly to the upsampling path, mitigating the information bottleneck and preserving structural details essential for SAR-to-optical alignment. The discriminator follows a PatchGAN architecture, which classifies local $N \times N$ image patches (specifically 70×70) as real or fake. This design emphasizes high-frequency texture accuracy and enforces local realism, while global structural coherence is implicitly guided by the reconstruction loss.

The training objective combines an adversarial loss $\mathcal{L}_{cGAN}$ to encourage realism with a pixel-wise reconstruction loss $\mathcal{L}_1$ to enforce data fidelity. The base objective is defined as:

$$G^* = \arg \min_G \max_D \mathcal{L}_{cGAN}(G, D) + \lambda \mathcal{L}_{\ell_1}(G) \quad (2)$$

where λ controls the weight of the reconstruction term. Consistent with literature standards [5,29], we set $\lambda = 100$. To further enhance perceptual quality, our final model augments this base objective with supplementary structural (SSIM) and perceptual (LPIPS) loss terms, as detailed in the following section.

3.4. Loss Functions

While the standard Pix2Pix framework employs Binary Cross-Entropy (BCE) for the adversarial objective, we observed training instabilities consistent with vanishing gradients. To mitigate this, we replaced BCE with the Least Squares GAN (LSGAN) loss [46], which penalizes samples based on their distance to the decision boundary, yielding more stable gradients and smoother convergence.

To simultaneously ensure pixel-level fidelity, structural consistency, and perceptual realism, the final objective function combines four complementary terms:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{total}} = \mathcal{L}_{\text{LSGAN}} + \lambda_{\text{L1}} \mathcal{L}_{\text{L1}} + \lambda_{\text{SSIM}} \mathcal{L}_{\text{SSIM}} + \lambda_{\text{LPIPS}} \mathcal{L}_{\text{LPIPS}} \quad (3)$$

where:

- $\mathcal{L}_{\text{GAN}}$ denotes the adversarial loss (LSGAN), encouraging the generator to produce outputs indistinguishable from real images.
- $\mathcal{L}_{\text{L1}}$ represents the pixel-wise reconstruction loss (MAE), enforcing global structural similarity between the generated and target images.
- $\mathcal{L}_{\text{SSIM}}$ is the Structural Similarity Index Measure loss, promoting local structural consistency.
- $\mathcal{L}_{\text{LPIPS}}$ denotes the Learned Perceptual Image Patch Similarity loss, which captures high-level perceptual differences.
- λ_{L1} , λ_{SSIM} , and λ_{LPIPS} are weighting coefficients that control the relative contribution of each term.

The weighting coefficients were set to $\lambda_{\text{L1}} = 100$, following the original Pix2Pix configuration [29], and $\lambda_{\text{SSIM}} = \lambda_{\text{LPIPS}} = 50$. These values were selected to balance low-frequency accuracy (L1) with high-frequency perceptual details (SSIM/LPIPS). The efficacy of this composite loss over individual configurations is quantitatively and qualitatively analyzed in the ablation study (Section 4.4).

3.5. Experimental Setup and Training Strategy

All experiments were implemented in Python 3.11 and PyTorch 2.4.0 using the official Pix2Pix implementation (<https://github.com/junyanz/pytorch-CycleGAN-and-pix2pix>) on an NVIDIA RTX A5000 GPU. The data consisted of the preprocessed SEN12-MS subset

described in Section 3.2.1, where each sample paired a Sentinel-1 SAR patch (VV and VH channels) with a corresponding 13-band Sentinel-2 optical patch.

Training followed a staged adversarial optimization scheme. The generator was first warmed up independently for 20 epochs to mitigate early instability, encountered in the early experiments. Subsequently, both networks were jointly optimized for a total of 150 epochs with a 1:1 update ratio, where the discriminator minimized the least-squares error and the generator minimized the composite objective. We employed the Adam optimizer [47] with a batch size of 16, an initial learning rate (LR) of 1×10^{-4} , and momentum parameters $(\beta_1, \beta_2) = (0.5, 0.999)$. To accelerate convergence, the generator's LR was adjusted via a ReduceLRonPlateau scheduler, which halved the rate whenever the validation L1 loss stagnated for 10 epochs (patience). The discriminator's LR was kept constant throughout to preserve stable adversarial dynamics.

Model performance was monitored via quantitative metrics—specifically L1, SSIM, and LPIPS calculated on the validation set after each epoch—and qualitative visual inspections of generated samples every ten epochs. The checkpoint yielding the lowest validation L1 loss was retained as the best-performing model.

3.6. Evaluation Metrics

The effectiveness of SAR-to-optical image translation depends not only on the choice of translation models but also on the methods employed for quality assessment. As discussed in [48], Image Quality Assessment (IQA) serves two key purposes: (i) to objectively evaluate the quality of results produced by different models, and (ii) to guide the optimization of network architectures and algorithms.

Moreover, evaluating SAR-to-optical translation requires assessing both pixel-level accuracy and perceptual quality. While some studies suggest metrics like SSIM, MSE, and LPIPS align well with human perception [48], our survey of 16 related studies (summarized in Table 1) indicates that SSIM, PSNR, and SAM remain the standard in current literature, whereas perceptual metrics like LPIPS appear less frequently. This trend aligns with the observations reported in the literature survey by [49]

Accordingly, we employed a hybrid evaluation strategy. We used PSNR and MAE/RMSE for pixel-wise fidelity, SSIM for structural integrity, and SAM for spectral consistency—crucial for multispectral data. To address perceptual realism often missed by pixel-based metrics, we also computed LPIPS.

Table 1. Frequency of common evaluation metrics in SAR-to-optical and cloud-removal studies.

Metric	References	Frequency
SSIM	[1,7,11,16,23,25,31,40,41,43,55,56]	12
PSNR	[1,2,7,23,25,31,40,41,43,55–57]	12
SAM	[1,2,5,16,23,40,41,43,55,58]	11
FID	[11,23,25,31,55,58]	6
RMSE	[2,5,7,16,40]	5
LPIPS	[1,7,31,56,58]	5
MAE	[2,40]	2
MSE	[41,57]	2

3.6.1. Metric Definitions

SSIM

The Structural Similarity Index (SSIM) [50] evaluates perceptual quality by comparing local luminance, contrast, and structure, thereby accounting for visual sensitivity to structural distortion:

$$\text{SSIM}(x, y) = \frac{(2\mu_x\mu_y + c_1)(2\sigma_{xy} + c_2)}{(\mu_x^2 + \mu_y^2 + c_1)(\sigma_x^2 + \sigma_y^2 + c_2)} \quad (4)$$

where μ_x, μ_y are means, σ_x^2, σ_y^2 are variances, and σ_{xy} is the covariance. Values close to 1 indicate strong structural similarity.

PSNR

The Peak Signal-to-Noise Ratio (PSNR) quantifies reconstruction quality by measuring the ratio of maximum signal power to the Mean Squared Error (MSE). For two images x and y , it is defined as

$$\text{PSNR}(x, y) = 10 \cdot \log_{10} \left(\frac{MAX^2}{\text{MSE}(x, y)} \right), \quad (5)$$

where the MSE is given by

$$\text{MSE}(x, y) = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^N (x_i - y_i)^2. \quad (6)$$

Here, x_i and y_i denote the pixel values of the generated and reference images, N is the total number of pixels, and MAX represents the maximum pixel intensity (e.g., 255). While higher PSNR values indicate lower distortion, the metric is limited by its purely pixel-wise formulation and often correlates weakly with human visual perception [31].

SAM

The Spectral Angle Mapper (SAM) [54] evaluates spectral fidelity by treating the spectrum of each pixel as an n -dimensional vector and measuring the angle between the generated vector x and the reference vector y :

$$\text{SAM}(x, y) = \arccos \left(\frac{\langle x, y \rangle}{\|x\|_2 \cdot \|y\|_2} \right), \quad (7)$$

where $\langle \cdot, \cdot \rangle$ denotes the dot product and $\|\cdot\|_2$ is the Euclidean norm. The result is typically expressed in degrees, with smaller values indicating higher spectral similarity. Because SAM considers only vector direction rather than magnitude, it is invariant to illumination changes, making it ideal for multispectral analysis [1].

LPIPS

The Learned Perceptual Image Patch Similarity (LPIPS) [52] measures distance in deep feature space using a pretrained network. It captures high-level semantic similarity closer to human visual judgment than traditional metrics:

$$\text{LPIPS}(x, y) = \sum_l w_l \cdot \|f_l(x) - f_l(y)\|_2, \quad (8)$$

where $f_l(\cdot)$ represents the feature activations in layer l and w_l denotes learned weights. Lower values indicate higher perceptual realism. Since standard LPIPS models are trained on 3-channel inputs, we computed the metric using the representative RGB stack of the multispectral images.

MAE & RMSE

Mean Absolute Error (MAE) and Root Mean Square Error (RMSE) provide direct quantitative assessments of pixel-wise error, with RMSE being more sensitive to outliers:

$$\text{MAE} = \frac{1}{N} \sum |y_i - x_i|, \quad \text{RMSE} = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N} \sum (y_i - x_i)^2}. \quad (9)$$

These metrics are calculated using the same pixel-wise notation (x_i, y_i, N) defined previously for PSNR/MSE.

A brief summary of the evaluated aspects, advantages, and limitations of each metric is provided in Table 2.

Table 2. Summary of evaluation metrics for SAR-to-multispectral translation.

Metric	Aspect Evaluated	Key Characteristic
SSIM	Structural similarity	Captures local texture/structure; intensity-based
PSNR	Pixel-level fidelity	Interpretable, but weakly correlated with perception
SAM	Spectral fidelity	Illumination invariant; ignores spatial context
LPIPS	Perceptual similarity	Deep feature-based; aligns with human vision
MAE/RMSE	Reconstruction accuracy	Direct error estimate; sensitive to outliers (RMSE)

4. Results

This section may be divided by subheadings. It should provide a concise and precise description of the experimental results, their interpretation as well as the experimental conclusions that can be drawn.

4.1. Subsection

4.1.1. Subsubsection

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- First bullet;
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- Third bullet.

Numbered lists can be added as follows:

1. First item;
2. Second item;
3. Third item.

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4.2. Figures, Tables and Schemes

All figures and tables should be cited in the main text as Figure 2, Table 3, etc.



Figure 2. This is a figure. Schemes follow the same formatting.

Table 3. This is a table caption. Tables should be placed in the main text near to the first time they are cited.

Title 1	Title 2	Title 3
Entry 1	Data	Data
Entry 2	Data	Data ¹

¹ Tables may have a footer.

Table 4. Sentinel-2 MSI spectral bands with central wavelength and spatial resolution

Band	Central Wavelength [nm]	Resolution [m]
B1	443 (Aerosols)	60
B2	490 (Blue)	10
B3	560 (Green)	10
B4	665 (Red)	10
B5	705 (Red edge)	20
B6	740 (Red edge)	20
B7	783 (Red edge)	20
B8	842 (NIR)	10
B8a	865 (Red edge)	20
B9	945 (Water vapour)	60
B10	1375 (Cirrus)	60
B11	1610 (SWIR)	20
B12	2190 (SWIR)	20

The text continues here (Figure 3 and Table 5).

424

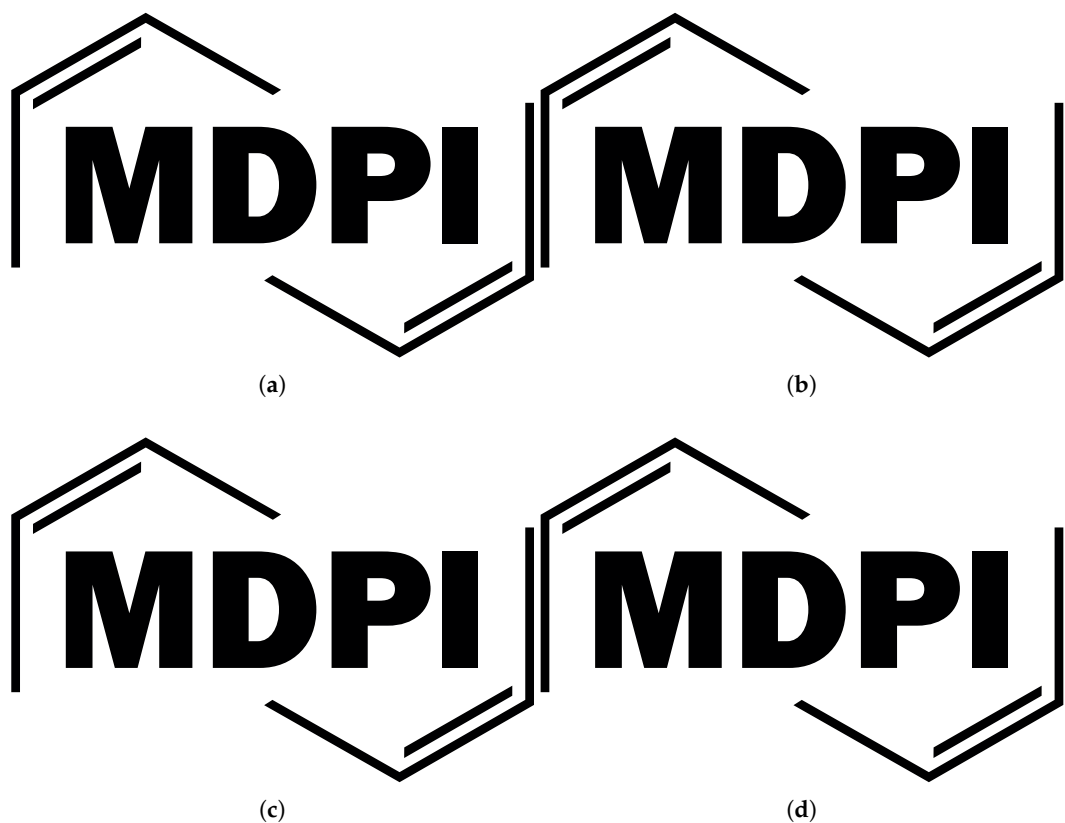


Figure 3. This is a wide figure. Schemes follow the same formatting. If there are multiple panels, they should be listed as: (a) Description of what is contained in the first panel. (b) Description of what is contained in the second panel. (c) Description of what is contained in the third panel. (d) Description of what is contained in the fourth panel. Figures should be placed in the main text near to the first time they are cited. A caption on a single line should be centered.

Table 5. This is a wide table.

Title 1	Title 2	Title 3	Title 4
Entry 1 *	Data	Data	Data
	Data	Data	Data
	Data	Data	Data
Entry 2	Data	Data	Data
	Data	Data	Data
	Data	Data	Data

* Tables may have a footer.

Text.

Text.

425

426

4.3. Formatting of Mathematical Components

427

This is the example 1 of equation:

428

$$a = 1,$$

(10)

429

the text following an equation need not be a new paragraph. Please punctuate equations as regular text.

430

431

This is the example 2 of equation:

432

$$a = b + c + d + e + f + g + h + i + j + k + l + m + n + o + p + q + r + s + t + u + v + w + x + y + z \tag{11}$$

433

Please punctuate equations as regular text. Theorem-type environments (including propositions, lemmas, corollaries etc.) can be formatted as follows:

434
435

Theorem 1. *Example text of a theorem.*

436

The text continues here. Proofs must be formatted as follows:

437

Proof of Theorem 1. Text of the proof. Note that the phrase “of Theorem 1” is optional if it is clear which theorem is being referred to. □

438
439

The text continues here.

440

4.4. Ablation Study on Loss Functions

441

5. Discussion

Authors should discuss the results and how they can be interpreted from the perspective of previous studies and of the working hypotheses. The findings and their implications should be discussed in the broadest context possible. Future research directions may also be highlighted.

6. Conclusions

This section is not mandatory, but can be added to the manuscript if the discussion is unusually long or complex.

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Author Contributions: For research articles with several authors, a short paragraph specifying their individual contributions must be provided. The following statements should be used “Conceptualization, X.X. and Y.Y.; methodology, X.X.; software, X.X.; validation, X.X., Y.Y. and Z.Z.; formal analysis, X.X.; investigation, X.X.; resources, X.X.; data curation, X.X.; writing—original draft preparation, X.X.; writing—review and editing, X.X.; visualization, X.X.; supervision, X.X.; project administration, X.X.; funding acquisition, Y.Y. All authors have read and agreed to the published version of the manuscript.”, please turn to the [CRediT taxonomy](#) for the term explanation. Authorship must be limited to those who have contributed substantially to the work reported.

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Written informed consent for publication must be obtained from participating patients who can be identified (including by the patients themselves). Please state “Written informed consent has been obtained from the patient(s) to publish this paper” if applicable.

Data Availability Statement: We encourage all authors of articles published in MDPI journals to share their research data. In this section, please provide details regarding where data supporting reported results can be found, including links to publicly archived datasets analyzed or generated during the study. Where no new data were created, or where data is unavailable due to privacy or ethical restrictions, a statement is still required. Suggested Data Availability Statements are available in section “MDPI Research Data Policies” at <https://www.mdpi.com/ethics>.

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Abbreviations

The following abbreviations are used in this manuscript:

- MDPI Multidisciplinary Digital Publishing Institute
- DOAJ Directory of open access journals
- TLA Three letter acronym
- LD Linear dichroism

Appendix A

Appendix A.1

The appendix is an optional section that can contain details and data supplemental to the main text—for example, explanations of experimental details that would disrupt the flow of the main text but nonetheless remain crucial to understanding and reproducing the research shown; figures of replicates for experiments of which representative data are shown in the main text can be added here if brief, or as Supplementary Data. Mathematical proofs of results not central to the paper can be added as an appendix.

Table A1. This is a table caption.

Title 1	Title 2	Title 3
Entry 1	Data	Data
Entry 2	Data	Data

Appendix B

All appendix sections must be cited in the main text. In the appendices, Figures, Tables, etc. should be labeled, starting with “A”—e.g., Figure A1, Figure A2, etc.

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